

Randomized and low-rank approximation

Sharp gap between volume sampling and the worst matrix with a prescribed spectrum

Difficulty: challenging **Importance:** interesting to the community

Status: open quantitative subquestion of a source updated 2026-08-20.

Problem statement

For $n \geq 3$, $1 \leq k \leq n - 2$, and $\lambda \in (0, \infty)^n$, write $K_V = V^T \text{diag}(\lambda)V$, $V \in O(n)$, and define

$$x_k(\lambda) = \max_{V \in O(n)} \min_{|I|=k} \text{tr}(K_V - (K_V)_{:I} (K_V)_{II}^{-1} (K_V)_{I:}), \quad y_k(\lambda) = (k+1) \frac{e_{k+1}(\lambda)}{e_k(\lambda)},$$

where $e_j(\lambda) = \sum_{|I|=j} \prod_{i \in I} \lambda_i$. Determine, up to universal multiplicative constants, the dependence on n, k of

$$R_{n,k} = \sup_{\lambda \in (0, \infty)^n} \frac{y_k(\lambda)}{x_k(\lambda)}.$$

Here y_k is the expected trace error when the selected subset has probability $\det((K_V)_{II})/e_k(\lambda)$. The question compares that expectation with optimal subset selection after an adversary chooses the eigenvectors. This order of quantifiers is essential. The endpoint $R_{n,n-1} = 1$ is known and excluded. The displayed supremum is a concrete subquestion of the source's request for spectrum-dependent tightness bounds; stronger bounds retaining the full spectrum would also be valuable.

References

Amsel et al., [workshop report](#), §4.2, Problem 4.7 and equations (15)–(16). Mark Fornace and Michael Lindsey, *Column and Row Subset Selection Using Nuclear Scores: Algorithms and Theory for Nyström Approximation, CUR Decomposition, and Graph Laplacian Reduction*, §4 and Appendix C, for determinantal sampling and the elementary-symmetric-polynomial formulas.

Status check

Searches included "minimax" "volume sampling" "2026", "volume sampling" "worst" "spectrum" "2026", and "volume sampling" "tightness" Fornace. No matching sharp estimate for $R_{n,k}$ was located. Generic column-subset approximation guarantees do not by themselves settle this spectral minimax ratio.